

THE BEGINNER GUIDE

Your AI brain starts with a folder

Give your AI a few useful files and some guidance about how you work. You can then start a fresh chat without explaining the whole project again.

YOUR STARTING SETUP

The computer you already own
One folder for your notes
An AI app that can read and write that folder

Start with one project

Use the starter folder, add two or three files, answer a few questions and ask for one useful piece of work. You can add more when you need it.

IN YOUR DOWNLOADS

This nine-page guide, including the system diagram
Six copy-paste prompts: ai-brain-prompts.txt
A blank folder: ai-brain-starter.zip

Start with pages 2-4

Let the AI interview you and organise the notes. You can answer in ordinary language. You can start without learning Markdown, setting up GitHub or installing Obsidian.

Pages 6-9 explain the larger setup. Obsidian, phone access, connected apps, computer use, GitHub and a dedicated computer are all **optional extras**. Add one only when you have a job for it.

Based on the AI with Kyle live session, 7 September 2026. The starter contains blank templates for your own information.

STEP 1

Connect the folder

Unzip ai-brain-starter.zip to get My AI Brain. Or make an empty folder with that name and let the AI create the notes after your interview. The blank starter is a shortcut.

In ChatGPT Work or Codex

1. In the desktop app, add a **local project** for this folder. In the project menu, use **Edit project** and **Add folder** when needed.
2. Select **My AI Brain**. If the project has several folders, make this one primary. Start a chat inside that project.
3. Choose **Codex** for the setup shown in the session, or use ChatGPT Work locally. Pick GPT-6 Astra if it is available in your account. Review any access request before approving it.

If you are using ChatGPT in a browser, upload or connect your files to a project. That is a separate route; it does not open your local folder.

WHAT IS INSIDE?

My AI Brain/	
START_HERE.md	Where to begin
about-me.md	Your preferences
current-project.md	Your current job
AGENTS.md	Short AI instructions
sources/	Original files
outputs/	Generated work

Add two or three useful files

Copy a brief, some audience notes or an example of your writing into **sources**. You can also start with the interview alone and add files later. The .md files are plain-text notes; your AI can fill them in for you.

Start with files you are comfortable sharing with your AI provider. Local files can still be sent to a cloud model for processing. Leave passwords and confidential customer records out. Back up the folder.

Setup reference: [OpenAI: projects and local folders](#)

STEP 2

Tell it how you work

Paste the setup prompt below. Answer its questions by typing or using voice dictation. Ramble if you need to; correct the summary afterwards.

COPY THIS: SET UP MY BRAIN

I want a simple folder you can use to understand me and my work, help me to set it up, explain things in ordinary language and interview me before you decide what belongs in my folder.

Read START_HERE.md, about-me.md and current-project.md if present. If I started with an empty folder, create simple notes after the interview. Interview me one question at a time. Ask about what I do, who I help, my current projects, decisions I have made and how I like to work. Explore what I want to BE, DO and HAVE: the person I want to become, the things I want to do and the things I want in my life. Ask deeper follow-up questions when my answers are vague. I may answer with a messy voice note. Treat blank template fields as unknown.

Show me a short summary to correct. After I approve it, save my preferences in about-me.md and the current job in current-project.md. Create or update START_HERE.md with links to these notes. Keep instructions in AGENTS.md short and consistent with what I approved.

Look only at relevant files in sources/. Leave those originals unchanged. Add links to the files you use. Put generated work in outputs/. Flag missing or conflicting facts instead of filling them in. Do not send, publish, buy anything or connect accounts.

Finish by suggesting one useful job we can do with the files already here.

Read the summary before it saves

Check who you help, your current goal and your preferences. Remove anything you would rather keep out of the folder. Let it save the corrected version.

Be, do and have

Give answers that mean something to you. For example: become a more confident speaker; run a small workshop; have more free evenings. Ask it to keep questioning you until it understands the details.

Typing and voice both work. You can give it this guide as context and ask it to walk you through one step at a time.

STEP 3

Give it one useful job

Choose a result you can check quickly: a launch email, a proposal draft or an agenda for a meeting.

COPY THIS: FIRST JOB

Read START_HERE.md, my preferences and the current project. I need [specific result] for [person or audience] by [date]. Use [named files in sources/].

Make [one concrete deliverable] and save it in outputs/. Follow my preferences. Use the source files for names, dates, prices and requirements. Link to them so I can check your work. List missing information separately. Stop before sending or publishing anything.

For example

"I need a launch email for my workshop. Use the workshop brief and my audience notes. Write one email in my voice, plus a short list of details I still need to supply. Save the draft in outputs/."

Check it against the files

Open the output. Check important dates, names and numbers. If it has guessed a fact or missed your tone, tell it exactly what to change.

A useful correction

"I never use countdown language in my emails. Show me a short preference we can save, then rewrite this draft without it."

Once you approve a lasting preference, save it in about-me.md. Keep a one-off request with that particular job.

STEP 4

Check it works next time

Open a fresh chat in the same local project. Ask this before giving it the next job.

COPY THIS: FRESH-CHAT CHECK

Read `START_HERE.md` and the notes it links to. What am I working on, who is it for, and which preferences should you follow? Name the files you used. Flag blank or conflicting information. Do not edit anything yet.

If the answer is wrong

Check that you opened the right project and folder. Ask it to read the notes by name. Fix the source note if it contains an error. A chat reply only becomes reusable folder context when it is saved there.

When something changes

Add a dated source file and say which fact changed. Ask your AI to update the affected notes and drafts, preserve the original sources and show the changes. The matching prompt is in your download.

Optional extra: try another model

Try Sol or Terra for repeat jobs, as discussed in the session. Run the same fresh-chat check and inspect the result. Keep Astra for jobs that need more judgment. Changing models can change the result.

Optional extra: another AI app

You can point another local-file AI app, such as Claude Code, at the same folder. Tell it: "I have an AI second brain at [folder]. Read `START_HERE.md` and explain how you will use it for this task." Confirm its folder access. Saved notes and outputs can carry across apps; separate chat histories may remain separate.

A USEFUL FIRST FINISH LINE

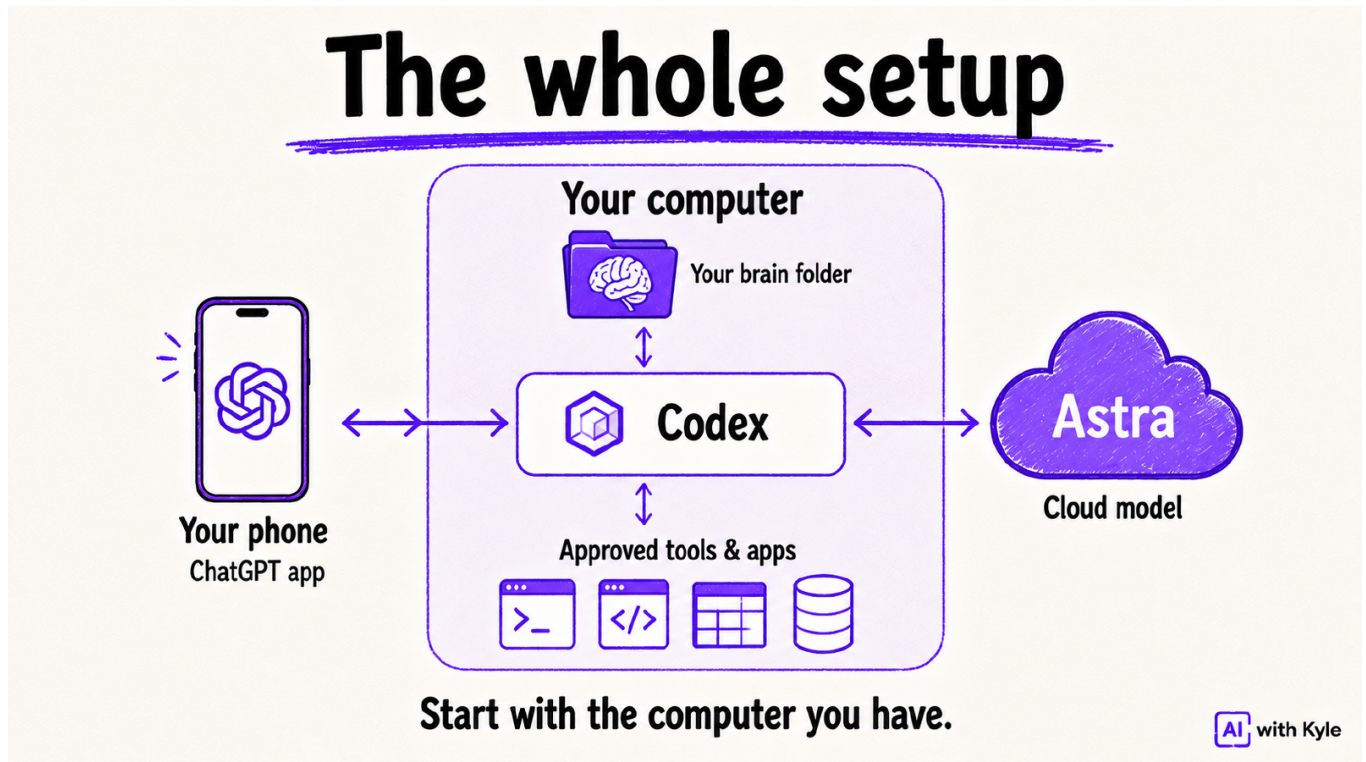
Your folder has information you checked. Your AI has made one useful draft from it. A fresh chat can read the notes and explain the job. You can keep working with that setup.

Official model guidance: [OpenAI: choosing models](#)

THE SYSTEM DIAGRAM

Start with the middle

The folder sits on your computer. Codex reads the files you allow it to use and works with the selected AI model.



The basic setup

Your computer + your brain folder + Codex + an available model. Astra is the model used in the session. You can keep this small and do useful work from the desktop.

Optional extra: your phone

The phone lets you send instructions and check work on a connected computer. The computer still runs the local task. You can leave phone access unconfigured.

Optional extra: approved tools and apps

Connect an app when a specific job needs it. Each connection has its own permissions. Your notes folder can be useful before you connect anything.

Local files, cloud processing

Astra runs in the cloud. Keeping the folder on your computer still allows selected content to be sent to the model. Share only material you are allowed and comfortable to share.

OPTIONAL EXTRA

See it in Obsidian

Obsidian gives you a way to read these same notes and browse the links between them. Your AI can use the folder without it.

1. Install Obsidian from obsidian.md/download.
2. Choose **Open folder as vault**, then select **My AI Brain**. A vault is Obsidian's name for your notes folder.
3. Open **START_HERE.md**. Follow a link to your project or preferences.
4. Open the built-in **Graph view**. Dots are notes; lines are links between them. Click a dot to open the note.

KEEP THE GRAPH SMALL

The starter already contains a few links. As you add notes, ask your AI to add useful links between related files. A bigger graph is not a measure of better AI answers.

You can leave Obsidian for later

Your AI can use the folder without it. You do not need extra plugins, a paid sync service or a Mac mini to follow this guide.

Ask your AI to keep it readable

Prompt 5 asks for a few useful links and a small START_HERE page. Your AI can organise the notes while you read and correct them. Keep adding files that help with actual work.

Official instructions

Obsidian: [open an existing folder](#)

Obsidian: [graph view](#)

OPTIONAL EXTRAS

Give it access for a job

Start with the files in your folder. Add an app connection when you need information or an action that lives in that app.

Optional extra: connected apps

A plugin or connector can let your AI work with an approved service. For example, a task might need a document from your drive. Ask what the connection can read or change before enabling it.

Optional extra: computer use

Computer use lets the AI see and operate supported apps through their interface. It needs separate setup and permissions. Keep it off until you have a specific task for it.

COPY THIS: BEFORE CONNECTING AN APP

I want help with [specific task] in [named app]. Explain what access you would need, what information might leave my computer and which actions could change something. Prefer the app's dedicated integration if one is available. Show me a plan before connecting anything. Keep sending, publishing, deleting, spending and account changes for my explicit approval.

Review one connection at a time

Check the requested account and access. Start with a draft or a read-only job you can inspect. Close unrelated sensitive apps during computer use. Revoke access when you no longer need it.

Optional extra: record how you do the task

For repeat work, make a short screen recording while you explain the steps. Share a sanitised copy your AI app can read. Ask it to write a procedure for you to check. Keep passwords, customer information and unrelated windows out of the recording.

The starter prompts do not connect accounts or send anything. Those actions need a separate instruction from you.

Official instructions: [OpenAI: plugins](#); [computer use](#)

OPTIONAL EXTRAS

Use the setup from your phone

You can do the whole beginner setup at your desk. Phone access is useful when you want to check or steer a task while away from it.

Optional extra: ChatGPT Remote

In a supported desktop app, open Settings, then Connections and Control this Mac or PC. Follow the setup instructions, scan the QR code and approve access on devices you own and trust.

In the ChatGPT mobile app, open Remote and choose your connected computer and project. Keep that computer awake and online. Availability depends on your app rollout and workspace settings.

TRY ONE SMALL TASK

From your phone, ask it to read the current project and tell you the next action. Check the answer before asking it to change a file.

Optional extra: a dedicated computer

A separate Mac mini or another always-on computer can host ongoing work. Start on the computer you already have. Extra hardware can wait until you know why you need it.

Optional extra: a rented server

A VPS is a rented computer in a data centre. It needs more technical setup and separate app access. It is unnecessary for this beginner folder setup.

Optional extra: GitHub or another backup system

Back up your notes. Git can keep a change history; GitHub can hold a remote copy. Both can wait. If you choose GitHub later, keep personal notes private and check what you upload.

Optional extra: more work running in the background

For a nightly tidy-up, back up the folder, name the files it may change and require a change summary. Keep original sources and avoid automatic deletion. Leave the host computer and app awake and available for local scheduled work.

Official phone setup: [OpenAI: Codex Remote](#)

Written by AI with Kyle. Product menus and model availability can change; check the linked official instructions if your screen differs.

YOUR EXTRA RESOURCE

Watch the full video guide

Build Your AI Second Brain With GPT-6 Astra



WATCH THE FULL VIDEO GUIDE